civilization and a repository of knowledge drew substantially from Xuan Zang's laudatory accounts of the country.

As an example of what Xuan Zang has to say about Nalanda, here is an extract from his writings:

> The priests, to the number of several thousands, are men of the highest ability and talent. Their distinction is very great at the present time and there are many hundreds whose fame has rapidly spread through distant regions. Their conduct is pure and unblameable. They follow in sincerity the precepts of the moral law. The rules of this convent are severe and all the priests are bound to observe them. The countries of India respect them and follow them. The day is not sufficient for asking and answering profound questions. From morning till night they engage in discussion; the old and the youth mutually help one another . . . Learned men from different cities, on this account, who desire to acquire quickly a renown in discussion, come here in multitudes to settle their doubts and the streams (of their wisdom) spread far and wide. [1]

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The visits to India by Chinese traders and pilgrims also led to political curiosity and sometimes diplomatic contact. It is not surprising that it was during the relatively cosmopolitan rule of the Tang emperors, when the Central Asian route became a crowded corridor for luxury trade and travel, that six diplomatic missions were exchanged between the Tang court at Changan and Harsha's court at Kannauj (Kanyakubja). The contemporary Chinese scholar Zhang Yuan, in an article written for the Delhi University's *Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences* , [2] has given a detailed description of these missions, drawn from the Old and New Tang Dynasty annals.

Xuan Zang reports meeting Harsha in 640 CE and telling him about the Tang emperor. Harsha appears to have some idea about China, which he refers to as 'Mahacina'. Harsha had sent a diplomatic mission to Changan in 640 CE and this led to a total of six missions being exchanged among the two courts between 641 and 647 CE . While there are some details about the Chinese delegates and their activities in India, there is little information about the Indian missions, the members of which are described as 'Brahmans'.

The second Chinese mission, which arrived in India in 644 CE , stayed in